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James

James 1:1–11

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear James 1:1–11 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of James 1:1–11 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of James 1:1–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

James is writing this letter in Jerusalem, where James is an important leader among the Jewish believers. James writes a general letter that he does not intend for a specific church, person, or situation. James gives practical advice in his letter to all believers about how to live their lives as believers. It is possible, but not likely, that there was only one copy of the letter and that someone then took it to each community of believers one at a time. It is more likely that somebody made several copies of the letter, and then several people each took a copy of the letter with them to read it to a small number, or a community, of believers.

At the time James wrote this letter, most writers of letters like this would start the letter in the same way. The letter writer would say who was writing the letter, then to whom they were writing, and then add a greeting. James does this, and then James gives a summary of what the letter will be about.

James starts by saying that he is James, a servant of God and a servant of the Lord Jesus Christ. When James says that he is a servant, or slave, of the Lord Jesus Christ, James is showing that he has great humility and great respect for Jesus and God the Father. James says that he is writing the letter to the “12 tribes” who are now living in groups in many different places outside of Jerusalem. The 12 tribes were the descendants of the 12 sons of Jacob. This probably means that James is writing his letter for the Israelites, or Jews, who are now followers of Jesus and living outside of Jerusalem. It is likely that there were communities of believers around the eastern end of the Mediterranean Sea. It is possible that non-Jewish believers were also part of the groups that James was writing to.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel during James’ time and the surrounding area as a group. The map shows where there were communities of Jewish people who no longer lived in Jerusalem. Pause this audio here.

Now, James talks directly to the believers he is writing the letter to. James calls the believers “brothers and sisters,” although they are not blood relatives of James. The believers are brothers and sisters because, with James, they are all part of God’s family.

James begins by telling the believers that they can be very glad, or have joy, when difficult things happen to the believers. Joy is more than just being happy. Someone has joy when they are thankful to God and strongly trust God.

James says that if the believers can experience the difficult things and still trust and believe in God as strongly as before, then the believers will become mature, or perfect, and will have everything they need. James does not mean that the believers will have all the material possessions they need, or that they will never make mistakes. James means that the believers will be spiritually mature. In this letter, James talks several times about the believers being perfect, or mature.

What James is saying is that when believers go through difficult things, the believers learn to trust and rely on God all the time, not just when something goes wrong. To trust God becomes a normal part of a believer's life, not just something a believer does when things are hard. And when a believer has learnt to trust God all the time, they are fully mature, or "perfect." That believer is complete, or able to trust God, because they have everything they need to trust God.

The difficult things that James is talking about can be when people treat someone badly because that person follows Jesus. Difficult things can also be the hard things, like death, sickness, and loss, that happen to people every day.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture or community, what "difficult things" do people experience in their everyday lives? This could be things like not having enough money to buy food for your family, too much or too little rain to grow food, or difficulties traveling somewhere. Pause this audio here.

James then says that if the believers do not know how God wants them to live like they fully trust God, then the believers should ask God to make them wise. God will give the believers the wisdom they ask for freely and generously, and will not make the believers do anything in return. This shows that God loves and cares for the believers. James is not saying that God will give the believers everything they ask for, or that God will always tell the believers exactly what to do in every situation. James is saying that if God makes the believers wise, the believers will understand *how* God wants them to live and how to go through the difficult things.

James then says that when the believers ask for wisdom, the believers must have confidence in God, rather than confidence that God will answer their prayer. The opposite of having confidence in someone, or trusting someone, is to doubt that person. James says that the person who doubts God is like a wave in the sea or on a lake. The wind is blowing the wave so that the wave is always moving, but is not going anywhere. For the Jews, the sea and waves often represented chaos, danger, and uncertainty, so this tells us that James thinks that doubt is a bad thing. A person who doubts is not just a person who cannot make a decision. A person who doubts thinks about following God, and then thinks about following other people who do not follow God. This person never fully commits to either side, so this person is always restless and never makes any progress. James says that God will not answer the person who doubts. A person who doubts will want to follow God and want to follow the people in the world, so this person will not be able to decide about anything that they do.

Stop here and look at a video of the wind blowing a wave around. Pause this audio here.

James goes on to talk about rich and poor believers. Poor believers have few possessions and a low social status. Rich believers have wealth and possessions. James says that both poor and rich believers can be "proud." In the Bible, when someone is proud, it is often a bad thing, but here James says that being proud in this way is a good thing. Here, when someone is proud, it means that the person rejoices or gives glory to God.

The humble believers can be proud because God gives them spiritual riches. James suggests that if rich or wealthy people understand that their wealth and status are temporary and do not last, then the rich people can also be proud. Both poor and rich believers should know that God does not value them based on how much money they have, but on how much these believers trust God and have a relationship with God.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture or community, what makes somebody rich? Is it money, or land, or something else? Does your culture value rich people more than poor people? How do you treat people who were once wealthy but lose their wealth? Pause this audio here.

James reminds the rich people that their wealth and status will not last forever, just like flowers that grow in the wild do not live forever. These flowers can be very beautiful, but when they are under a hot sun, the flowers can wither and die quickly. When James was writing this part of the letter, James might also have been thinking about the words of Jesus when Jesus said, “Do not store up treasures on earth where someone can destroy or steal them. Store up treasures in heaven. Your mind and heart will be focused on where your treasures are.”

Stop here and look at a photo of a flower flowering, a flower dying, and a flower shedding its petals.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of James 1:1–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the parts, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four parts.

In the first part: James starts the letter by saying who James is, who James is writing the letter to, and greets the Jewish believers.

In the second part: James tells the believers it is important for them to continue to trust God when the believers are going through various kinds of difficulties. God uses these trials to test the believers’ faith.

In the third part: James says that the believers need God’s wisdom in order to remain faithful to God, and so the believers should ask God for wisdom. James also encourages believers that when they pray to God, the believers should completely trust God.

In the fourth part: James says that both rich and poor believers should trust God and learn to think about poverty and wealth as God does.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- God
- Jesus Christ
- The Jewish believers who are not living in or close to Jerusalem
- Some Jewish believers who doubt God
- Some Jewish believers who are poor
- And some Jewish believers who are rich

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage’s setting:

Remember that James wrote this letter in Jerusalem. A person then traveled with the letter to the people James was writing to, and then somebody read the letter to the believers.

James starts his letter the same way most people wrote letters at this time. James begins this letter with who is writing the letter, who the letter is addressed to, and a greeting.

James says that he is writing the letter, and that he is James, a servant of God and a servant of the Lord Jesus Christ. James does not need to say anything else about who James is because everybody who hears the letter will know who is writing it. James says that he is writing the letter to the “12 tribes” who are living in the diaspora, or in many different places outside of Jerusalem. The 12 tribes were the 12 Jewish tribes that we hear about in the stories in the Old Testament. Here, James means that he is writing his letter to Jewish believers. The greeting that James gives is the same as saying “Hello.” The word that James uses is very similar to the word that means “joy,” so James’ greeting could also mean “Be glad” or “Be joyful.”

Stop here and discuss as a group: When you send a message to a group of people, how do you change your words or phrases based on whether those people know you or not? If you want to greet people joyfully in your culture, what word or phrase would you use to greet them? Think about whether this will change how you translate this letter. Pause this audio here.

In the second part of this introduction to his letter, James talks directly to the believers he is writing the letter to. James calls the believers “brothers and sisters,” although they are not blood relatives of James. The believers are brothers and sisters because, with James, they are all part of God’s family.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What words do you use when you talk to other believers that you know and love? Talk about how you will translate “brothers and sisters” in these passages. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that they can be very glad, or have joy, when difficult things happen to them. In other words, the believers can be thankful and strongly trust God when difficult things happen to them.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Talk about somebody who has a deep and thankful trust in God. Pay attention to the words and phrases you use when you are talking about this person. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers they can be glad because, as they experience difficult things, they will learn to trust God more and more. Eventually, these believers will learn to trust and rely on God all the time, not just when something goes wrong. These believers will be mature and complete. The difficult things that James is talking about can be when people persecute or treat believers badly. The difficult things can also be the difficult things that happen to people every day.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Talk about how a believer who is still immature would react to a difficult situation, and then how a believer who is mature would react to the same situation. Pay attention to the words and phrases you use when you are describing these people. Pause this audio here.

In the third part, James says that believers should ask God for wisdom. God will freely and generously give the believers the wisdom they ask for, and will not expect anything in return. This shows that God loves and cares for the believers. James is not saying that God will give the believers everything they ask for, or that God will always tell the believers exactly what to do in every situation. James is saying that the wisdom that God gives will help the believers to understand *how* God wants them to live and how to behave when difficult things happen.

James goes on to say that when the believers ask God for wisdom, the believers must trust God. The opposite of trusting God is doubting God. James talks about the person who doubts God by saying the person is like a wave that constantly moves in the sea or on a lake. This person is somebody who sometimes chooses to act in one way and then another time, decides to act in a different way. This person never fully commits to either side, so this person is always restless and never makes any progress.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Put some water into a bowl and have two or three people blow on the water to move it around. Notice how the water moves. Now, as you think about how the water moves, discuss what words or phrases you would use to talk about somebody who doubts in the way that James describes. Pause this audio here.

In the fourth part, James says that both rich and poor believers should trust God and learn to think about being poor and being rich in the same way that God thinks about these things.

The humble believers can be proud because God gives these believers spiritual riches. The wealthy believers can be proud if they understand that their wealth and status are temporary and do not last. Both poor and rich believers should know that God does not value them based on how much money they have, but on how much they trust God and have a relationship with God. James reminds the rich people that their wealth and status are temporary, just like flowers that grow in the wild. These flowers can be very beautiful, but when they are under a hot sun, the flowers can wither and die quickly.

James talks about wealth and possessions that do not last. James might have been thinking about the words of Jesus when Jesus said, “Do not store up treasures on earth where someone can destroy or steal them. Store up treasures in heaven. Your mind and heart will be focused on where your treasures are.”

Stop here and discuss as a group: Can you think of a plant, flower, or object that looks beautiful but does not last long in harsh conditions? How does this help you understand that money and things do not last forever? Will people easily understand the idea of a flower blooming and dying, or is there another description that would make more sense? Talk together about the words and images you will use when you translate this part of the passage. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it. You may want to use people or objects to show James, God, Jesus, and the different groups of believers. As you retell the story, you could have James stand with God and Jesus to show that James is their servant. You could have the different groups of believers stand in different parts of the space where you are, to show that the believers lived in many different places. Remember how James talks about waves moving around to show that people doubt, and how flowers die to show how money and things go away. How will you show these ideas?

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of James 1:1–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- God
- Jesus Christ
- The Jewish believers who are not living in or close to Jerusalem
- Some Jewish believers who doubt God
- Some Jewish believers who are poor
- And some Jewish believers who are rich

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

James says the words, and someone who is with James writes down what James says. As James speaks, the believers act out what James says.

James says, “I am James, a slave of God and a slave of the Lord Jesus Christ. I am sending this letter to all the Jewish believers who have left Jerusalem and are now living in other places. Hello!”

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers who are living in many other places, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I used to be part of the community of believers in Jerusalem. It is so good to know that I can still have teaching from James; or
- There are so many of us, and we live all over the place. I am glad that James is writing to all of us. It makes me feel like we are still part of the same church.

Continue the drama.

James says, “Brothers and sisters, you can be very glad when difficult things happen to you, because when difficult things happen to you, you will become stronger, and it will become easier to trust God. And when trusting God becomes a normal part of your life, not just something you do when things are hard, then you will be complete, and God’s work is done!”

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing James, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- It is difficult to say things like this when I do not know what difficult things these people are going through. I hope these people know that I want to encourage them; or
- I am sad that the Jewish believers had to leave Jerusalem. I would like to see the Jewish believers again.

Continue the drama.

James says, “If you do not know how to work through difficult situations, then you need to ask God for wisdom. Because God loves you and cares for you, God will give you wisdom freely and generously without conditions. God will not tell you exactly what to do, but God’s wisdom will help you understand how God wants you to live and how to get through the difficult things.”

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing God, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I love the believers, and I want to help them. It makes me sad when the believers do not ask me for wisdom; or
- Sometimes the believers behave like little children and then want me to do everything for them. I feel sad. I want the believers to grow up and be mature believers.

Continue the drama.

James then says, “When you ask God for wisdom, ask with confidence and trust, without doubt. A person who doubts God is like a wave in the sea or on a lake, which the wind blows about. The wave constantly moves but does not go anywhere. If you doubt, then God will not answer your prayer for wisdom.”

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers who the wind is blowing about, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am frightened. I am scared that if I ask God for wisdom, God might not answer me; or
- I am confused. I do not know what to do.

Continue the drama.

James says, “The community looks down on believers who are poor because they do not have wealth or possessions. But these believers can be proud because they have spiritual riches. The poor believers have spiritual riches because God honors them, and these believers have a future in God’s kingdom. And you believers who have wealth and possessions, you can also be proud because God also gives you spiritual riches. But you need to remember that wealth and status are temporary, just like flowers that grow in the

wild. These flowers can be very beautiful, but when they are under a hot sun, the flowers can wither and die quickly.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers who are poor, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- Sometimes, when people hate me and look down on me, it is very hard to remember that I have spiritual riches; or
- I am so glad that I have few possessions. I think it makes it easier for me to remember that I have spiritual riches.

Ask the person playing the believers who are rich, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am glad that James is reminding me that all my wealth and possessions are temporary; or
- I do not like to hear this. Sometimes I would rather have possessions that I can see and touch than spiritual riches.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of James 1:1–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

James starts his letter by describing himself as a servant, or slave. A slave belongs to a master and obeys the master, and the master has the right to tell the slave to do whatever the master wants him to do.

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you will use for **servant** or **slave**. If you have translated servant or slave in another book of the Bible, use the same word here. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about servant and slave. Pause this audio here.

James describes himself as a servant of God and the Lord Jesus Christ. Use the same word for God that you have used throughout your translation. Lord means “owner” or “master,” but in the Bible it has a special meaning. Lord is a title of respect and of authority. It is one title for God in the Old Testament, and in the New Testament, “Lord” usually refers to Jesus. In the letter of James, “Lord” usually refers to God, but in this greeting, James uses it for Jesus.

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you will use for **Lord** and **Christ**. If you have translated Lord or Christ in another book of the Bible, use the same word here. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about Lord and Christ. Pause this audio here.

James is writing this letter to the 12 tribes who live in the diaspora, or in many different places around the world. The 12 tribes refer to the descendants of the 12 sons of Jacob. This is another way to talk about the Jewish people. Because James is writing the letter to believers, we can assume that James is writing to Jewish people who had become followers of Jesus and had moved away from Jerusalem to live in other places. Some people think that James was writing the letter for all new believers who live in other places, not just to Jewish believers. James calls these other places the diaspora, which means that people live in many different cities and nations. You may say that these people live in many different places or nations.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **12 tribes** and **diaspora**. Pause this audio here.

James addresses the believers as **brothers** here and several more times throughout this letter. We can be certain that James also wanted women to hear his letter. Some translations use the words “brothers and sisters,” and some simply say “believers.” The believers are not the blood relatives of James. The believers are brothers and sisters because, with James, they are all part of God’s family.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **brothers** or **brothers and sisters**. If you choose to use a word for **believers**, refer to the Master Glossary for more information about believers. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that they can be very glad or full of joy when bad things happen to test their faith. When someone has faith, that person trusts that God is good and that God will do what he has promised, even when it seems impossible. Joy is a deep happiness that people have when they know and trust God, no matter what happens.

Stop here and discuss what words or phrases you will use for **joy** and **faith**. If you have translated joy in another book of the Bible, use the same word here. Discuss what word or phrase you will use for faith. If you have translated faith in another book of the Bible, use the same word here. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about faith. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that trials will test their faith. Trials are difficult situations or challenges that test how strong you are, how patient you are, or how much you trust God. Trials can come from problems that are often beyond your control, such as losing a job, having a serious illness, or dealing with a natural disaster.

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you will use for **trials**. If you have translated trials in another book of the Bible, use the same word here. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that when bad things test their faith, the believers will have more perseverance. When someone perseveres, they continue to trust God again and again, even when hard things happen.

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you will use for **perseverance**. If you have translated perseverance in another book of the Bible, use the same word here. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that when someone perseveres, that person becomes perfect and complete. This means the person keeps trusting God and does not give up during difficult times. As the believers continue through these challenges, their character and trust in God will grow stronger. In the end, the believers will be perfect, or completely mature. Just like a piece of fruit is mature when it is fully developed and ready for people to use, a person is perfect or mature when they consistently act like someone who is wise and ready to work. When a person is complete, they are whole—they have everything they need to do good work.

Stop here and discuss what words or phrases you will use for **perfect** and **complete**. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about perfect. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that if they are not wise and do not know how to live a faithful life, or they lack wisdom, they should ask God to make them wise, or to give them wisdom. Wisdom here means to understand how God wants the believers to live.

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you will use for **wisdom** in this passage. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about wisdom. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that when they ask God for wisdom, they should believe, or have faith, and not doubt. To believe something is to trust something so much that you are willing to do what you believe. Doubt is the opposite of believing.

Stop here and discuss what words or phrases you will use for **believe**, or have **faith**, and for **doubt**. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about belief and faith. If you have translated doubt in another book of the Bible, use the same word here. Pause this audio here.

James says that a person who doubts is double-minded. This is the first of only two places in the Bible where authors use this word. When a person is double-minded, they want to do two different things at the same time, and they do not know which thing to do. This is the opposite of loving God with an undivided, or whole, heart. When someone loves God with a whole heart, that person thinks only about God himself and what God wants that person to do. When someone is double-minded, they think about more than just what God wants them to do, and these things confuse that person so that they do not know what to do.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **double-minded**. Pause this audio here.

James tells the poor and humble believers and the wealthy believers to take pride in their positions. In the Bible, being proud is often a bad thing, but here James uses it in a good way. Here, to be proud means to rejoice, or to give glory to God.

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you will use for **pride** in this passage. Pause this audio here.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

James 1:12–18

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear James 1:12–18 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of James 1:12–18 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of James 1:12–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous part of this letter, James said believers who trusted God through difficult times could be truly happy because difficulties made their faith strong.

In this part of James' letter, James talks again about believers who continue to trust God through difficult times. Here, James says that believers who continue to trust God through difficult times can be truly happy, because God has promised to give a "crown of life" to these believers. James is not thinking about a real crown that a king or queen wears. James is thinking about the crown of leaves that the winner of a race in Greek and Roman times wears. In ancient Greek and Roman times, races were important events at big festivals like the Olympics. People ran in a race to show that they were strong and skillful. Other people respected and honored the winners of races. People gave the winners prizes like money and wreaths that people made of leaves. People admired winners and treated them like heroes.

Stop here and look at a picture of a person giving a crown of leaves to a Greek athlete who has won a race. Pause this audio here.

James does not mean that God will give only one believer, or a small number of believers, a real crown. James is talking to all the believers who continue to trust God through difficult times. James says that God will give these people the reward of life forever with God.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture or community, how do you honour or reward someone who has been brave and persevered, or continued to do the right things, through difficult times? Pause this audio here.

James has been talking about trials, or difficult situations, that believers have as they go through life. Now James talks about temptations. A temptation is when a person has an opportunity to get what they want or do what they want, but in a way that is not good or right. Someone has a temptation when they have a very strong desire to do an evil thing. James says that God does not give the believers anything that would harm the believers, because that would be a bad thing to do, and God cannot do bad things. Therefore, God does not tempt people. Instead, people want to do bad things so much that it seems like their desire to do these bad things forces the people to do them! James says temptation is like a bait that people put in a trap to catch an animal, or onto a hook to catch a fish.

Stop here and look at pictures of a trap with bait for animals, and a fishing hook with bait to catch fish. Pause this audio here.

James goes on to say what happens when someone falls into a trap or gives in to temptation. James compares what happens to when a woman becomes pregnant and then gives birth to a baby. The baby then grows up, and when the baby is fully grown, it also gives birth. James is saying that a person's evil desires lead that person to sin, and then their sin makes them spiritually dead. When someone is spiritually dead, they are separated from God, even when they are physically alive.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Sometimes, difficult situations can make a person want to do bad things. For example, a person who is ill might want to blame God for not making the person better, or a person who does not have enough money might want to steal money from somebody else. Tell a story about a person who did bad things because that person was in a difficult situation. Pause this audio here.

James really loves and cares for the believers, so James reminds the believers that all good things come from "the Father of lights." The Father of lights is another way to talk about God, the creator of the sun and moon and other heavenly bodies, or stars. This is a title for God that James only uses in this part of his letter, and no one else uses anywhere in Scripture. James says that God does not change. James refers to the changing patterns of light and shadow, which the movement of the sun, moon, and stars causes. James contrasts the changing light and shadow with God, who does not move or change.

James finishes by reminding the believers that it is God who gives us new life. This new life happens because God wants it, not because people earn it. The new life comes because people believe the good news or true words about Jesus.

Believers have new life, so they are the “firstfruits” of creation. In the Old Testament, we hear how Israelite farmers give God the first part of their harvest as a special gift. This shows that the people thank God for the harvest and trust God for the rest of the harvest. When James says that God gives “us” new life, James could mean two things. James might be saying that Israelite believers are God’s chosen people and were the first people to receive God’s blessings. Or James might be talking about all the followers of Jesus and suggesting that many more people will believe later. James does not make it clear which he means, but both ideas show that God has a bigger plan that starts with some people and will grow to include many more. However, the people who were the first people in the kingdom will hold a special place of honor in the history of God’s kingdom.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of James 1:12–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three parts.

In the first part: James tells the believers that God will give a reward that lasts forever to believers who continue to trust in God through difficult times.

In the second part: James talks to the believers about temptations.

In the third part: James reminds the believers that all good things, including new life, come from God.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- God
- The Jewish believers who are not living in or close to Jerusalem
- Some believers who receive the crown of life from God
- And some believers who are experiencing temptation

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage’s setting:

Remember that James is in Jerusalem and is writing to believers who are living in many different places.

In the first part, James says that believers who continue to trust in God through difficult times are happy, or blessed. James means that these believers are happy, or full of joy, because they are brave when they go through difficult times without giving up. You can use the same word for being happy or joyful that you used in the previous passage.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Listen to Jesus’ teaching in Matthew 5, where Jesus also says that people are blessed when they do certain things. What words did you use to translate the idea that people are “blessed” or happy in that passage? Do you like the way you translated it there? Do you need to use the same word or a different word in this passage? Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that if they continue to trust God through difficult times, God will give them a “crown of life.” James is not thinking about a real crown that a king or queen wears. James is thinking about the crown of leaves that the winner of a race in Greek and Roman times wears.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What words or phrases do you use when you talk about a person who wins a race or completes a difficult task? What reward or prize do people give the winner? Talk about how you will translate the idea of receiving a “crown of life.” Pause this audio here.

In the second part, James tells the believers that God does not tempt them because it is impossible for God to tempt the believers. But believers want to do evil things, and believers do these things. James talks about

“difficult times” and “temptations,” which are two different things. Difficult situations are when things that we cannot control happen to us and harm us. But temptations are when we are in difficult situations and really want to do something evil. If we do that evil thing, it will harm us or other people.

Stop here and discuss as a group: First, tell a story about a time when you were in a difficult situation that you had no control over. Then tell a story about a time when you were in a difficult situation and were tempted to do a bad thing. What did you do? Notice the words and phrases you use to describe the two different situations. Choose what words you will use for “difficult times” and “temptations” when you translate this passage. Pause this audio here.

Our evil desires are just like a bait or a trap that attracts an animal. We continue to want to sin until, finally, we give in and we do the sin.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Remember the story you told in step two about someone who sinned because they were in a difficult situation. Think about being in such a difficult situation when you really want to do something bad, and it is difficult not to do that bad thing. Remember the photo of the animal trap you saw in step two? How will you talk about your evil desires like bait in an animal trap that makes you want to sin? Pause this audio here.

James compares what happens when a person wants to sin to when a woman becomes pregnant. Then the woman gives birth to a baby. The birth of the baby symbolizes the person doing the sin. Then the person continues to sin, and it is like the baby grows up. When the baby fully grows up, it also gives birth to another baby. But this baby is death. In other words, James is saying that a person’s evil desires lead that person to sin, and when a person continues to sin, they die spiritually and no longer have a relationship with God.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do you appropriately describe the way a woman gets pregnant and gives birth to a baby in your culture? If it is difficult to talk about a woman getting pregnant and giving birth, how will you describe how evil desires lead to sin, which leads to separation from God? Pause this audio here.

Now stop and discuss as a group: Tell a story about a person who is spiritually dead. In other words, the person is physically alive but has no relationship with God. Talk about the words and phrases you use to describe this person as being spiritually dead. Pause this audio here.

James starts the third part of this passage by using a phrase that means James wants the believers to understand clearly what James is saying.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell your group something that is very important for them to know. Pay attention to the words, phrases, and gestures you use to make sure the group knows it is important. Talk about what words, phrases, and gestures you will use when you translate this part of the passage. Pause this audio here.

James calls the believers “brothers and sisters,” but James also says they are “dear” brothers and sisters. This means that James loves and cares for the believers.

Stop here and discuss as a group: You have already translated “brothers and sisters” in the previous passage. In your language, what word or phrase would you use to show that you care deeply for a group of people, even more than just calling them brothers and sisters? Pause this audio here.

James then reminds the believers that all good things come from “the Father of lights.” The “Father of lights” is another name of God, who is the creator of everything, including the sun and moon and other heavenly bodies, or stars. James contrasts the changing light and shadow of the sun, moon, and heavenly bodies, which move around in the sky, with God, who does not move or change.

Stop here and do this activity: Go outside and look at the shadow of a tree or a bush. If the wind is blowing, notice how the shadow moves. If the air is still, make a mark on the ground to show where the shadow is lying. Go away, but come back later and notice that the shadow has moved. Pause this audio here.

God is not like the shadow. God does not move or change.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you talk about the fact that God does not move like a shadow moves? Pause this audio here.

James finishes by reminding the believers that when they believe the true word, or message, from God, God chooses to give the believers a new and complete life. James says that he and these believers are like God's "firstfruits." You will remember that the firstfruits were the first and best part of the harvest that the Israelites would bring to dedicate to God. The Israelites then trusted that God would give much more harvest! Just like the firstfruits of the harvest are special to God, these believers are special to God. And God has an even bigger plan to include many more believers in his kingdom!

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you talk about the "firstfruits" of the harvest, or the fact that the believers who believe the true message from God are like the best part of the harvest? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of James 1:12–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- God
- The Jewish believers who are not living in or close to Jerusalem
- Some believers who receive the crown of life from God
- And some believers who are experiencing temptation

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first part of this letter, James talks again about believers who continue to trust God through difficult times. Here, James says that believers who continue to trust God through difficult times can be happy, because God has promised to give a "crown of life," or eternal life, to all the believers who continue to trust God through difficult times.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers who God is giving the crown of life to, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- This is wonderful. Sometimes it has been difficult to trust God, but I am glad that I did; or
- Some of my family members do not have this reward from God because they did not trust God all the time. That makes me sad.

Continue the drama.

James has been talking about trials, or difficult situations that believers face as they go through life. In this second part, James starts talking about temptations. A temptation is when a person wants to do something that will harm that person or somebody else in some way. James says that God does not give the believers anything that would harm them, because that would be a bad thing to do, and God cannot do bad things. James says that when a person does what they want to do, it can result in doing bad things, and when a person continues to do bad things, it can result in spiritual death. James uses the same words he would use to describe a woman who gives birth to a baby. James is saying that a person's evil desires lead that person to sin, and sin then leads to spiritual death.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing God, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am sad that the believers think that I would tempt them to do something bad; or
- I really want the believers to trust me and to make good decisions.

Continue the drama.

James calls the believers "brothers and sisters," but James also says they are "dear" brothers and sisters. This means that James loves and cares for the believers.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing James, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I love and care for the believers so much. It makes me sad that I cannot be with the believers in person; or
- I am sending this letter to the believers, but I do not know if the believers will listen to or understand what I am saying.

Continue the drama.

James then reminds the believers that all good things come from "the Father of lights." James refers to the changing patterns of light and shadow, caused by the movement of the sun, moon, and stars. James contrasts the changing light and shadow with God, who does not move or change.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Sometimes I forget that all good things come from God; or
- It is good to be reminded that God never changes, unlike the sunlight and moonlight that are always changing.

Continue the drama.

James finishes by reminding the believers that it is God who gives new life. New life happens because God wants it, not because people earn it. Believers receive this new life when they believe the true message from God. Then these believers are like the best part of the harvest, and there is still more harvest to come!

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Sometimes I need to be reminded that my life as a believer is a gift from God and that I have done nothing to earn it; or
- It is exciting to know that we are the firstfruits and there are more believers to follow.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of James 1:12–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

James starts this passage by telling the believers that they are blessed if they persevere, or continue to trust God in difficult times. If someone is blessed, it can sometimes mean the person is receiving a blessing from God. Here, blessed means very happy, or full of joy.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **blessed**. Bless does appear in the Master Glossary, but in this passage, it has a different meaning. Remember, you have already translated this word when you translated Jesus' teaching in Matthew 5. You could use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that they are blessed if they persevere, or continue to trust God in difficult times or in **trials**. Trials are difficult situations or challenges that test your strength, patience, or faith. If you come through the difficult situation well, you will be stronger, you will be more patient, and you will trust God more. Use the same word for trial that you used in the previous passage.

James tells the believers that the **Lord** has promised the believers a crown of life. Here, Lord refers to God. Use the same word or phrase for Lord as you have used in previous passages.

James tells believers about God's promise of a special reward called the crown of life. This is not a real crown like kings wear. Instead, it is like the leaf crown that people gave to the winners in ancient Greek and Roman races. In those races, only the first-place winner received a crown. But James says all believers who keep trusting God during hard times will get this reward. The crown of life is not a physical crown. It is a way to describe the gift of eternal life that God gives to faithful believers.

Stop here and look at a picture of a person giving a crown of leaves to a Greek athlete who has won a race. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **crown of life**. Pause this audio here.

In this passage, James talks about trials and temptations. Temptations are not just about having a strong desire to have something or an opportunity to do something. Someone has a temptation when they are in a situation to get something they want, but they would have to do something bad to get it. For example, people might want to lie or steal to get something they want. Or people may want to do something bad to someone who wronged them so that they feel like there is justice.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **temptations**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that they must not say that God is tempting them, because evil things cannot tempt God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **evil**. Look up evil in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that having evil desires can lead someone to sin. If a person has an evil desire, that person wants to do or have something that is wrong or will harm themselves or somebody else. When someone sins, they disobey God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **sin**. Look up sin in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in other books of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James says that sin can lead to death. Here, death does not mean physical death, which is when you stop breathing, and your body stops working. Here, death means spiritual death, which is when you can no longer have a relationship with God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **death**. Pause this audio here.

James addresses the believers as **brothers and sisters**. Use the same word or phrase that you used for brothers and sisters in the previous passage. Here, James calls the believers “dear” brothers and sisters, or brothers and sisters whom he loves very much. This means not only that the believers are members together of God’s family, but that James really cares for the believers.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about the **dear**, or loved, brothers and sisters. If you have already translated this idea in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that God gives them perfect gifts. Here, perfect means that anything that comes from God is complete, and pure, and without any flaws. This means that anything God gives is exactly what we need, and given with love, and reliable, because God never changes.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **perfect** in this situation. Refer to perfect in the Master Glossary for more information about a perfect thing. Pause this audio here.

James gives God the title of “Father of lights.” The lights are the sun, moon, and stars. James says that God is the father of the believers because God created the believers. This is the only place in the Bible where the storytellers give God the title of “Father of lights.”

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Father of lights**. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that God chose to give them birth, or new life, through the “word of truth.” This new life comes because people believe in God through the good news or true message about Jesus.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **word of truth**. Look up word in the Master Glossary for more information. Pause this audio here.

James describes the believers as firstfruits. In the Old Testament, God commanded his people to bring the first and best parts of their harvest as a special gift for God. This showed that the people thanked God for the harvest and trusted God for the rest of the harvest. People sometimes use firstfruits’ to describe other things that are special to God, as in this passage, where it describes the believers.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **firstfruits**. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about firstfruits. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

James 1:19–27

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear James 1:19–27 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of James 1:19–27 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of James 1:19–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

James has been writing to the believers and encouraging them to continue to trust God in difficult times. Now James tells the believers that they should not only listen to God's word, but that they should also obey God's word.

James begins by reminding the believers that not only are James and the believers all part of God's family, but that James loves and cares for the believers.

James wants to share something very important with the believers. These instructions are so important that James uses a pattern of words to help the believers remember.

James gives the believers three instructions. James tells the believers to always be ready to listen to what other people are saying. James tells the believers to take time to think about what they say before they say anything. James also tells the believers not to get angry quickly or easily. James is not talking about when people are angry in a good or righteous way. James is talking about when people are angry in a bad way. James tells the believers that the reason they should not get angry in this way is that when people are angry in a bad way, it does not help them to live the right kind of life that God wants them to live.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when you were angry in a bad way. What things did you do when you were angry? Were these good things to do, or bad things? Pause this audio here.

Instead of becoming angry, which does not lead to the life that God wants us to have, James tells the believers to do something different. James tells the believers they must listen to and obey the word of God. To do this will save the believers from the results of sin. First, James tells the believers to stop doing evil things. James uses words that people can also use to describe how a person takes off dirty clothes when James tells believers to take off, or stop doing, evil things. Then James encourages the believers to accept God's word, or message. James uses words that describe a seed that someone plants in the ground so that it grows and

produces fruit. God's word is like a seed that God plants in people that grows and changes how people act and think. In other words, James tells the believers that before the believers can hear and obey the word of God, the believers must stop doing all the bad things they are doing.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when you had to tell a group of people to stop doing bad things. How did you feel when you told the people to stop doing these evil things? How did the people respond? Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that they are wrong if they think they can listen to God's word and not obey God. The believers must also *do* what God's word says. God's "word" is what God says to the believers through Scripture, through Jesus, and through the teachers in the church. James says the believers who do not obey what God's word says are like people who study carefully their faces in a mirror and then walk away from the mirror and forget what their faces looked like! A mirror was a round piece of polished metal that people used to see reflections of themselves. James contrasts the people who forget what their faces looked like with people who look carefully into the mirror and then do what they need to do. These are the believers who study God's word carefully and then do what God wants them to do. James describes this as "looking intently" into the "perfect law." The "perfect law" is completely good. This law is all the commands and instructions that God has given his people to live by, including the teachings of Jesus. When we keep sinning, it is as if we lock ourselves into a prison that we cannot escape from. But when we obey God's word, God opens the door and sets us free to live the way God wants. God blesses the person who pays close attention to what God's word says, and then does it.

Stop here and look at a picture of a mirror. Pause this audio here.

In the third part of this passage, James tells the believers that if a person cannot control what he says but thinks he is living a good life, that person is wrong. When James talks about the tongue, James is not talking about the literal tongue in a person's mouth. Instead, James is talking about the words that people say. A rein or a bridle is the ropes or leather straps on a horse's head that a person uses to control the horse. James is comparing how someone who is able to control what that person says is like a person who controls his horse.

Stop here and look at a picture of a man riding a horse and controlling the horse with a bridle. Pause this audio here.

James goes on to say that the way of life that pleases God is pure and clean, or genuine. James then lists two things that please God. Firstly, believers should take care of orphans and widows when they are suffering. An orphan usually means a child who has no parents, but here it probably means a child who has no father. Widows are women whose husbands are dead. In Jewish society, fathers and husbands looked after and cared for the family. A family that had no father or husband would need help more than others because they had no man to provide for them or to protect them.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture or community, how do people protect and look after others who need help? Who are the people who most need help? Pause this audio here.

James finishes this part of his letter by saying that the second thing that pleases God is to avoid the evil behaviour that people in this world do.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of James 1:19–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the parts, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three parts.

In the first part: James encourages the believers to listen carefully, think before they speak, and not act in an angry way. Believers instead should stop acting in an evil way and accept and do what God's Word says to do.

In the second part: James tells the believers to study God's word carefully and obey it.

In the third part: James encourages the believers to speak carefully and describes the way that God wants us to live.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- The believers
- Believers who listen to God's word but do not obey God's word
- Believers who listen to God's word and obey it
- Orphans
- Widows
- And God

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first part, James calls the believers dear brothers and sisters for the second time. James often uses the phrase "brothers and sisters" to show that he is going to start talking about something different. Then James uses a phrase that means that what James is going to say next is important and that the believers need to understand and remember what he says. James also mentions the three themes that he is going to talk about: listening, speaking, and being angry. James uses a pattern of words that would make it easier for the believers to remember the important instructions that James gives them about these subjects. James says the believers should be quick to listen, slow to speak, and slow to be angry.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about when you had to say something very important to a group of people, and you wanted them to remember what you said. Notice what words, phrases, or gestures you used so that the group knew what you were saying was important and would remember what you said. Pause this audio here.

James shows the difference between how the believers should listen to people and talk to people. James says believers should be quick to listen and slow to speak. This means the believers should always be ready to listen to what other people are saying and take time to think about those things before they say anything in return. Then James tells the believers not to get angry quickly or easily. James is not talking about people being angry in a good or righteous way. James is talking about when people are angry in a bad way. When people are angry in a bad way, they often hurt other people. James tells the believers they should not get angry in this way because it does not help them to live a righteous life, or the kind of life that God wants them to live, in good relationship with him.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about being quick to listen and slow to speak. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers they must get rid of all the bad things they are doing. The words James uses for getting rid of something are the same words that people use to talk about taking off dirty clothes. James uses two words to emphasise how bad the things are that the believers are doing. James says that these actions are "dirty," or morally wrong. James even says that these actions are evil. James may have been thinking about the evil behaviour and customs that were common in the non-Jewish society around these believers at the time James was writing this letter.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about taking off or getting rid of the bad things believers are doing. Remember your discussion from step two about how you told a group of people to stop doing bad things. How will you translate this part of James' letter so that it is clear that James is strongly telling the believers to stop doing bad things? Pause this audio here.

Only when the believers take off these dirty clothes—the sins—will they have room in their lives for something new. James says the believers must humbly accept the word of God that God plants in them. God's word is like a seed that somebody plants in the ground. It needs space to grow. If the believers listen to and obey the word of God, it is like a seed that will grow and produce right behavior, like a seed produces fruit. God's word, when people follow it, saves them!

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will describe people accepting the word of God that God plants in them. Pause this audio here.

In the second part, James tells the believers that they are wrong if they think they can listen to God's word and not obey it. The believers must also do what God's word says. God's "word" here is what God says to the believers through Scripture, through Jesus, and through the teachers in the church. James says these believers who do not obey God's word are like people who look in a mirror and maybe see dirt on their face, and then walk away from the mirror and forget to wash the dirt off. A mirror was a round piece of polished metal that people used to see reflections of themselves. James contrasts the people who walk away from the mirror and forget with people who look carefully into the mirror and then do what they need to do. Those who look in the mirror and do what they need to do are like the believers who study God's word carefully and then do what God wants them to do. James describes this kind of action as "looking intently" into the "perfect law." The perfect law is completely good. This law means all the commands and instructions that God has given his people to live by, including the teachings of Jesus. When we keep sinning, it is as if we lock ourselves into a prison that we cannot escape from. But when we obey God's word, God opens the door and sets us free to live the way God wants. God blesses the person who pays close attention to what God's word says and then does it.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a time when you gave instructions to two groups of people. One group listened to the instructions and then did the task that you had given them. The other group listened to the instructions but did not do the task you had given them. Pay attention to the words, phrases, and gestures you use when you are talking about the two groups of people. How will this help you translate what James says about listening to the word of God and then doing what God wants? Pause this audio here.

In the third part, James tells the believers that if a person cannot control what he says but thinks he is living a good life, he is wrong. That person's life is worthless because he is not living as God wants him to live. James uses the picture of a person's tongue to show what he means. The tongue represents the words that people speak. A person who cannot control what he says is someone who is not wise when he uses words. That person may use words to tell lies, to make people sad, or to cause trouble. James is saying that a person who is able to control what that person says is like a person who controls his horse by pulling on the reins.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about someone who does not control what he says, a person who causes trouble and says unwise words. Pay attention to the gestures, words, and phrases you use when you are talking about this person. Talk about how you will translate this part of James' letter. Pause this audio here.

James goes on to say that religion, or the way we live and worship God, should be pure and clean. If a person lives purely, that means that they are totally devoted to do whatever God asks that person to do. Similarly, if a person lives cleanly, they live in a sincere way that pleases God. James lists two things that please God. Firstly, James says it pleases God when believers take care of other people in the community who have nobody to look after them, like widows and orphans. Secondly, James says that it pleases God when believers live in a way that is different from the other people in the world who do bad things. James uses words that compare the good way believers live to the way a person keeps their clothes or bodies clean, or makes sure that their clothes or bodies do not have dirty spots.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will describe the way believers live and worship God as pure and clean. Also, discuss how you will talk about acting differently from how people in the world act. Will you use words that compare the way believers act to staying clean? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it. You may want to use people or objects to show James, God, and the different groups of believers. You may want to have the different groups of believers stand in different parts of the space where you are to show that the believers lived in many different places. There are several contrasting ideas in this passage. For example: being ready to listen or being quick to get angry, just listening to God's word or listening to God's word and doing it, seeing your dirty face in a mirror and taking the dirt off or seeing your dirty face in a mirror and then walking away. As you retell the story, you may want to have some people do the "good action" and others do the "bad action."

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of James 1:19–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- The believers
- Believers who listen to God's word but do not obey God's word
- Believers who listen to God's word and obey it
- Orphans
- Widows
- And God

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first part, James calls the believers dear brothers and sisters. James tells the believers to always be ready to listen to what other people are saying. James tells the believers to take time to think about what those people say before the believers say anything in return. James also tells the believers not to get angry quickly or easily. James tells the believers that the reason they should not get angry in this bad way is that it does not help them to live the right kind of life that God wants them to live.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing James, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- What I am saying to the believers is really important. I would like to tell the believers myself, but I cannot be with them all. I have to trust that the person reading this letter to the believers understands that this is important for the believers to hear; or
- I hope I am saying this in the right way. I do not want the believers to think I am angry with them.

Continue the drama.

James says that if the believers want the right kind of life, they should get rid of all the evil in their lives. Then the believers can accept and follow God's Word that God has planted in their hearts, like a person plants a seed. God's Word is powerful. When the believers follow God's Word, it saves the believers' lives.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I understand James is telling us to stop doing bad things, but sometimes it is very hard to be different from the people around me; or
- When James writes about this, I can see that what I have been doing is wrong, but I want to be different.

Continue the drama.

In the second part, James describes two groups of believers. Firstly, James talks about the believers who are mistaken because they think they can listen to God's word and not follow it. The second group of believers is those who pay careful attention to what God's word says, and then do what God wants them to do. James says that God blesses the person who pays close attention to what God's word says and then does it.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers who are listening but not doing what God wants them to do, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel really bad. I think James is talking about me. Somebody must have told James that I am not following God's word; or
- I wish James would not say these things to us. James does not understand what it is like to be a believer in my situation.

Continue the drama.

In the third part, James tells the believers that if a person cannot control what he says, but thinks he is living a good life, he is mistaken. A person who cannot control what he says is someone who is not wise when he uses words. That person uses words to tell lies, to make people sad, or to cause trouble. James is saying that a person who is able to control what that person says is like a person who controls his horse with a rein.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am sad. I think I have been living a good life, and I thought God was pleased with me, but now I understand that I have not been careful about what I say. I did not realize that what I say is very important to God; or
- I see now there are many areas of my life where God is not pleased with me. I need to spend more time finding out what God wants me to do and doing it.

Continue the drama.

James goes on to say that the way of life that pleases God is pure, clean, and genuine. James lists two things that please God. Firstly, to take care of people in the community who have nobody to look after them, and secondly, not to behave like the evil people in this world.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I can think of people in my community who the community is not looking after. I know I must do something to help those people; or

- I am glad that God has told James to remind us not to behave like the evil people in this world. I needed to hear it again.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of James 1:19–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

James addresses the believers as **dear brothers and sisters**. Use the same phrase that you used for dear brothers and sisters in the previous passage.

James tells the believers that when they are angry in a human or bad way, they cannot live in a way that pleases God. When people are angry in a bad or human way, it is a strong emotion and is often a reaction to a situation where a person feels threatened or hurt. For this reason, when a person is angry, they can damage things and hurt people. When a person is angry like this, that person is selfish, and nothing good happens. When a person is angry in a selfish way, it is different from when God is angry, because when God is angry, God is getting rid of sin and evil, and God's anger produces good things.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **human anger** in this passage. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that when people are angry, it does not produce the righteousness that God wants from his people. Here, James means the right behaviour or actions that God wants from God's people. These right actions cause us to have a good relationship with God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **righteousness**. Look up righteousness in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The believers must get rid of dirt and wickedness. James uses dirt to represent the bad and wicked things that people do. Wickedness means the same as evil. Evil is the opposite of good.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **wickedness**. Look up wickedness in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that they must listen to the **word** and also do what it says. God's "word" here is what God says to the believers through Scripture, through Jesus, and through the teachers in the church. Use the same word that you have used in previous passages for word, and refer to the Master Glossary for more information.

God's word saves the believers' souls. When people use the word soul, they sometimes mean the invisible part of a person where a person thinks, feels, and wants things. Here, James uses the word soul to refer to the whole person.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **soul**. Look up soul in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James says that listening to God's word is like looking into a mirror. A mirror was a round piece of polished metal that people used to see reflections of themselves.

Stop here and look at a picture of a **mirror**. Then discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for mirror. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that they must study God's law carefully because God's **perfect** law gives freedom. A law is a rule or a set of rules that people have to keep. God's laws are the set of instructions and commands

that God gave to the Jewish people and then to the believers. God's perfect law is completely good and has everything in it that we need. Use the same word or phrase for perfect as you have previously, and refer to perfect in the Master Glossary for more information. When people obey God's law, it frees those people from wanting to disobey God and makes it possible for them to do what God wants them to do. Sin no longer has control of people when they are free.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for God's perfect **law** and for **freedom**. Look up law in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

When believers follow God's perfect law, God blesses the believers. When God blesses someone, God shows that person favor and does good things for them.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **bless**. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about bless. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers they need to control what they say in the same way that a person controls a horse with a rein or bridle. A rein or a bridle is the ropes or leather straps on a horse's head that a person uses to control the horse.

Stop here and look at a picture of a **rein** or **bridle**. Then discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for a rein or bridle. Pause this audio here.

James says that the religion that pleases God is pure and clean, or without fault. Religion is a system of belief and faith, or a way that people regularly worship God and what they believe about God. This religion that pleases God is the way that believers trust in Jesus and live as God's people. Something that is pure is not mixed. Something that is pure has only good things in it, not several good and bad things that people mix together.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **religion** and **pure**. Look up pure in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

When James says that believers should not allow the world to make them dirty, James is saying that believers should not allow the evil actions that non-believers in the world do to influence believers to do evil things.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will describe "**the world**."

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

James 2:1–7

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear James 2:1–7 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of James 2:1–7 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of James 2:1–7 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

James begins this part of his letter by again calling the believers brothers and sisters. James wants to again remind the believers that they are all members together of God's family. Then James makes a strong statement and follows it up with a story to show what James means. James says that people who believe in Jesus must not honour some people more than others. The title that James gives Jesus is "our glorious Lord Jesus Christ." When something or someone is glorious or full of glory, they are majestic and wonderful. James is reminding the believers that Jesus is now with God and that Jesus is glorious because God is glorious! If we believe in Jesus like this, then we should never disrespect anyone!

James tells a story to help the believers understand what James means. James tells a story about a rich man and a poor man who both come into a meeting. It is not clear what sort of meeting this is, but it is most likely a gathering of believers. Although James is just telling a story, it is likely that James is thinking of real situations that he has seen or heard. In the story, the rich man has a gold ring and beautiful clothes. These items had high value in that culture, so the believers know that this man is rich and that the people in the community respect the rich man. In the story, the other man is wearing old and dirty clothes. The believers know that this man is poor and has no possessions, and that the people in the community do not respect the poor man.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a person in your community or culture who is important. What makes this person important? If you met this person for the first time, how would you know, by looking at them, that they are important? Tell another story about a person in your community or culture who is unimportant. What makes this person unimportant? If you met this person for the first time, how would you know they are unimportant? For example, it might be because they wear the same clothes every day, or because they have to walk everywhere. Pause this audio here.

In the story, the believers see the rich man and honour him. The believers care about the man and are interested in him. The believers offer the man a seat of honour. In the story, when the believers see the poor

man, they tell him he must stand up or sit on the floor. At the time when James lived, important people would sit on a fine chair with a low stool in front of it. The important people would rest their feet on this stool. People called this a footstool. Poor people would sit on the floor below the level of the rich person's feet on the footstool. When the believers tell the man to stand or sit on the floor, this means that they do not respect or honour him.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about an important person in your community, and an unimportant person in your community. How do people in the community welcome these people when the community meets together? How do people act towards the important person and the unimportant person? Is it difficult to act towards them in the same way? Pause this audio here.

James finishes the story by asking the believers a question. James asks, "Is it true that the way you have unfairly judged people shows that you have evil motives?" James is not asking for information and is not expecting the believers to answer the question. James is using this sort of question to emphasise what James is saying. James wants the believers to understand that it is wrong to honour somebody because they have wealth and possessions, and it is wrong to dishonour somebody because they do not have wealth or possessions. When the believers make these decisions, they are thinking the believers can decide who is worthy of honour. These believers do not have the authority to judge, and the believers judge with the wrong motives. Only God can judge people fairly, and only God has the authority to do so.

First, James told a story to show that it was wrong to honour rich people over poor people. Now, James gives the believers two reasons why it is wrong to honour rich people over poor people.

James tells the believers something really important. James again calls the believers brothers and sisters and asks the believers another question. James asks, "Is it true that God chose the poor in this world to strongly believe in God? Is it true that the poor people are the people who will inherit the kingdom God promised to those who love God?" Again, James is not asking for information and is not expecting the believers to answer the question. James is using this sort of question to emphasise what James is saying. James wants the believers to remember that God chooses people who seem unimportant in the world. When these poor and unimportant people believe in Jesus, they become spiritually rich because when they trust in Jesus, God sees them as valuable people. God will bless those people because God has promised that he will make everyone who trusts in God a citizen in God's kingdom. James is not saying that all poor and unimportant people are spiritually rich. James means that poor people who trust in God are spiritually rich. James may also be wanting the believers to remember that Jesus often talked about poor people receiving God's kingdom, or becoming citizens of God's kingdom.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Think about some unimportant believers whom the community does not value, perhaps because they are poor. But these unimportant people are also believers, and they are also going to be citizens in God's kingdom with you. How do you feel knowing that these people will live with you forever in God's kingdom? Pause this audio here.

Now James contrasts what the believers usually do with what God does. God chooses and honors the people who seem unimportant. The believers dishonour the people who seem unimportant.

James finishes by asking three more questions that James does not expect anyone to answer. James is reminding the believers of what they already know. James reminds the believers that it is the rich and important people in the community who are treating the believers badly, using their power against the believers, and making the believers suffer. James reminds the believers that the rich people are making false accusations against the believers and forcing them to go to court. To take someone to court means to take someone to a judge and ask the judge to say that you are right and the other person is wrong. A person does this so that the judge will punish the other person. James reminds the believers that the rich people are blaspheming, or insulting, the name of Jesus. James wants the believers to understand that just because a person is rich, it does not mean that person is good!

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of James 2:1–7 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the parts, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three parts.

In the first part: James tells the believers that they must not honour some people more than other people.

In the second part: James tells a story to help the believers understand what James means.

In the third part: James gives the believers two more reasons why they must not honour some people more than other people.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- The believers
- Jesus Christ
- A man who is dressed in beautiful clothes
- A man who is dressed in dirty clothes
- And God

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first part, James calls the believers brothers and sisters. James is reminding the believers again that they are all members together of God's family. Then James says that people who believe in "our glorious Lord Jesus Christ" must not honour some people more than others. When James uses "our," he means that James and the believers believe in the same Lord Jesus Christ. James describes Jesus as "glorious" because Jesus is now in heaven with God.

In the second part, James tells a story to help the believers understand what James means. In the story, a rich man and a poor man both come into a meeting. It is not clear what sort of meeting it is, but it is most likely a gathering of believers. In the story, the rich man has a gold ring and beautiful, expensive clothes. These items had high value in that culture, so the believers know the man is rich and the people in the community respect him. In the story, the other man is wearing old and dirty clothes. The believers know that this man is poor and has no possessions and that people in the community do not respect him. In the story, the believers offer the rich man a seat of honour, or the most important seat in the gathering.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what is the honorable seat or the best and most important place to sit? What do you call this place? Discuss how you want to translate the idea of a seat of honor. Pause this audio here.

In the story, when the believers see the poor man, they tell the man he must stand up or sit on the floor. At the time when James lived, important people would sit on a fine chair with a low stool in front of it. The important people would rest their feet on this stool. This was called a footstool. Poor people would sit on the floor below the level of the rich person's feet on the footstool. When the believers tell the man to stand or sit on the floor, this means that the believers do not respect or honour the man.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what is the least honorable seat or worst place to sit? What would people think about a seat that is next to or below someone else's feet? Discuss how you want to describe the way the poor people have to sit on the floor next to a footstool. Pause this audio here.

James finishes the story when James asks if the believers are creating differences between people and becoming judges with evil motives. James does not expect anyone to answer this question. James is using this sort of question to emphasise what James is saying. James wants the believers to understand that it is wrong

to honour somebody because they have wealth and possessions, and it is wrong to dishonour somebody because they do not have wealth or possessions. When the believers do this, they think that the believers can decide who is worthy of honour. The believers act like judges, who decide if a person has acted in a right or wrong way. Some judges are evil, and so they do not judge fairly. These believers are becoming just like judges with evil motives when the believers decide to honor one person more than another person.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a time when you wanted a group of people to understand something. You decided to tell the people a story to help them understand what you were saying. Why did you tell the people a story? Pay attention to the gestures, words, and phrases that you used when you told the story. How will you tell this story about the rich man and the poor man who came into the meeting? Pause this audio here.

James starts the third part with a word that tells the believers that they need to listen and pay special attention to what James is about to say. James calls the believers dear brothers and sisters again to remind them that he is writing to them as a brother and that he cares for them and loves them. James really wants the believers to understand what James is saying.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a time when you wanted a group of people to pay special attention to what you were going to say. What gestures, words, and phrases did you use to make sure they were listening to you? Pause this audio here.

James asks the believers another question. James asks if it is true that God has chosen the people who are poor or unimportant in this world to be important in God's kingdom. Again, James is not asking for information and is not expecting the believers to answer the question. James is using this sort of question to emphasise what he is saying.

Now, James wants the believers to remember that God chooses people to be a part of his kingdom who seem unimportant in the world. When these poor and unimportant people believe in Jesus, they become spiritually rich because the way they trust in Jesus gives the believers value. God will bless these people, and God has promised that everybody who trusts in God will inherit the kingdom of God. The kingdom of God does not refer to a country on Earth. This kingdom is everywhere God rules. In this kingdom, people belong to God, obey God, and live in a right relationship with God. All things belong to God, and God shares good things with believers, both now and in the future. The believers inherit or receive these good things when they inherit the kingdom of God.

Stop here and discuss how you will describe being "rich in faith," or "spiritually rich." How will you describe that the believers are spiritually rich because they inherit the kingdom of God? In your language, how do you talk about the way that someone is rich or has a lot of something good, but that good thing is not something you can touch, like money? In other words, someone is "rich" when they have a good relationship with God and others. Pause this audio here.

James is not saying that all poor and unimportant people are rich in faith, but only those poor people who love God. James may also be wanting the believers to remember what Jesus said in Matthew 5: "God blesses the poor in spirit, who are those who know that they need God, because God has given those people the ability to become citizens of God's kingdom."

James starts the next part with a word that contrasts what God does and what the believers do. God chooses the people who seem unimportant to be in God's kingdom. But the believers dishonour the people who seem unimportant.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about two people who did different things. Think of a moment when one person acted in one way, and the other person acted in a completely different way. As you tell your story, notice the gestures, words, and phrases you use when you are drawing attention to the difference between the actions. Pause this audio here.

James finishes by asking three more questions that James does not expect anyone to answer. James is reminding the believers of what they already know. James reminds the believers that it is the rich and important people in the community who are treating the believers badly. The rich people in the community use their power against the believers and make the believers suffer. James reminds the believers that the rich people are making false accusations against the believers and forcing them to go to court. James reminds the believers that the rich people are blaspheming, or insulting, the honorable name. But this is the name, or person, to whom the believers belong! Though James does not say which name this is, this name is probably Jesus's name. When Jesus calls a name over someone, it means that this person becomes Jesus' possession and has a special relationship to Jesus. In that time, a person's name was also closely related to their reputation. If someone insulted a person's name, they insulted that person's reputation and character. So James means that when the rich people insulted the believers who belonged to Jesus, those people also insulted Jesus.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What kind of family names do you have, or what names do you share with other members of your family or tribe? If someone insults or dishonors you, how does your family feel about that? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when you were talking to a group of people and had to tell those people something they already knew. What gestures, words, and phrases do you use when you are telling somebody something that they already know? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it. You may want to use people or objects to show James, God, and the different groups of believers. You may want to have the different groups of believers stand in different parts of the space where you are to show that the believers lived in many different places. As you retell the story, you may want to have the rich man and the poor man come into one of the groups of believers. You can have another believer offer the rich man a chair to sit on and tell the poor man to sit on the floor.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of James 2:1–7 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- The believers
- Jesus Christ
- A man who is dressed in beautiful clothes
- A man who is dressed in dirty clothes
- And God

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first part, James calls the believers brothers and sisters. Then James says that people who believe in “our glorious Lord Jesus Christ” must not honour some people more than others.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I do not understand why James is saying this to us. Our community of believers is open to everyone; or
- I am glad that James is saying this. When I became a believer, I did not feel like the other believers welcomed me.

Continue the drama.

In the second part, James tells a story to help the believers understand what James means.

Remember, this is a story that James is telling to the believers. This story is not really happening, but it is important for you to act out the story.

In the story, a rich man and a poor man both come into a meeting, probably a gathering of believers. In the story, the rich man has a gold ring and beautiful clothes. In the story, the other man is wearing old and dirty clothes. The believers who are in the meeting show honour to the rich man and offer him a seat. But the believers who are in the meeting show disrespect to the poor man. The believers tell the poor man he must stand up or sit on the floor. James asks if the believers are creating differences among people and becoming judges with evil motives. But James already knows that this is what the believers are doing. James wants the believers to understand that it is wrong to honour somebody because they have wealth and possessions, and it is wrong to dishonour somebody because they do not have wealth or possessions.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the rich man, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- It is right that the other believers gave me a good seat in the meeting, where people can see me; or
- I feel bad that the other believers have given me a good seat. The poor man who came into the meeting at the same time as me has to sit on the floor. We are both believers. I think people should treat us in the same way.

Ask the person playing the believers who are watching the story, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel bad. This reminds me of what has happened in some of our meetings; or
- It is not right that the poor man has to sit on the floor. The poor man should be allowed to sit down next to the rich man.

Continue the drama.

James says, “Listen to what I will say, dear brothers and sisters!”

James asks if it is true that God has chosen the unimportant people to have faith, which is truly valuable, and to be citizens of God’s kingdom. This is certainly true!

However, while God chooses the people who seem unimportant, the believers dishonour the people who seem unimportant!

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing God, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- It makes me sad when I see the believers acting in a disrespectful way towards the people that the community thinks are unimportant. I created those people, and I care about those people. I want the believers to value those people like I do; or
- It makes me angry when I see the believers acting in a disrespectful way towards the people that the community thinks are unimportant.

Continue the drama.

James reminds the believers that it is the rich and important people in the community who are treating the believers badly, using their power against the believers and making the believers suffer. James reminds the believers that the rich people are making false accusations against the believers and taking them to court. James reminds the believers that the rich people are blaspheming, or insulting, the name of God.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of James 2:1–7 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

James addresses the believers as **brothers and sisters** and **dear brothers and sisters**. Use the same words or phrases that you used for “brothers and sisters” and “dear brothers and sisters” as you have in a previous passage.

James says that believers in our glorious Lord Jesus Christ must not show favoritism. “Lord” is a title of respect and shows that Jesus has authority and power. “Jesus” is his human name. “Christ” is the Greek word for Messiah or Anointed One. To describe Jesus as “glorious” means that he is wonderful and majestic, just like God is!

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for the title “glorious Lord Jesus Christ.” Look up glory, Lord, and Christ in the Master Glossary for more information. Translate Lord and Christ in the same way you have previously. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers they must not show favoritism. Another way to say this is to say that the believers must not honour some people more than others.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for showing **favoritism** or honoring someone. If you have already translated this idea in another book of the Bible, translate this idea in a similar way. Pause this audio here.

James tells a story about a rich man and a poor man who both come into a meeting. Although James is just telling a story, it is likely that James is thinking of real situations that he has seen or heard. In the story, the man has a gold ring and beautiful and expensive clothes. These items had high value in that culture, so the believers know the man is rich and the people in the community respect him. In the story, the other man is wearing old and dirty clothes. The believers know that this man is poor and has no possessions, and people in the community do not respect him.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use when you describe the rich man and the poor man and how people treat them. Pause this audio here.

James says that the believers act like judges with **evil** motives. Evil is the opposite of good. A judge is someone who has the authority to decide if a person’s actions are right or wrong. A judge will punish the person if the judge decides that the person is guilty of doing wrong. These believers make decisions about others as if these believers have authority to do so. But these believers make the decisions with evil or bad motives! For more information on evil, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word for evil that you used in previous passages.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **judge**. Look up judge in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that God has chosen those whom the world sees as unimportant to be rich in **faith**. If you believe in someone or have faith, you believe that what that person says about himself is true. You then trust that person and are committed to do what that person tells you to do. Here, James is talking about having faith in God. For more information on faith, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word for faith that you used in previous passages.

James says that having faith makes a person rich because they will inherit the kingdom that God has promised to give them. A kingdom is an area that a king rules. Here, James is talking about the kingdom of heaven, or the kingdom of God, where God rules.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **kingdom**. Look up kingdom of God in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The rich people take the believers to court. To take someone to court means to take someone to a judge and ask the judge to say that you are right and the other person is wrong. A person does this so that the judge will punish the other person.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about taking someone to **court**. Pause this audio here.

James talks about the rich people who are blaspheming the name of God. This means that the rich people are insulting the name of God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use **blaspheming**. Look up blasphemy in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

James 2:8–13

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear James 2:8–13 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of James 2:8–13 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of James 2:8–13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous part of James' letter, James told the believers that they must not honour some people more than others. In this part of his letter, James tells the believers that if they honour some people more than others, they are breaking God's law.

James tells the believers that God's royal law in Scripture says "love your neighbour as yourself." James calls God's law "the royal law" because it comes from God, who is the most important king! James also says the law comes from Scripture. When James talks about Scripture, James is referring to God's words that people had written down in the Old Testament. Old Testament law was the law for the people of Israel, and the people of Israel believed that their neighbors were people who were part of the same community as them. You will remember that in the book of Luke, however, Jesus shows that we should love even more people than we thought we should! In Luke, we hear that a man asked Jesus to explain to him who his neighbors were. Jesus told that man a story about one man who helped an injured man, even though the two men were from different people groups who hated each other. Jesus told this story to explain that everybody we meet is our neighbour. The story that Jesus told shows that we should love everybody we come into contact with, regardless of their background or social status. When we love somebody, we choose to do kind things for that person, respect them, and look after their physical needs. James tells the believers that if they are obeying this law to love their neighbor as they love themselves, they are doing the right thing.

Stop here and listen to your translation of Luke 10:25–37, where Jesus tells the story of the good neighbor. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a group of people whom your community does not accept. Why does your community not accept these people? How does your community treat these people? Do these people have to live in a different place, or are there places these people are not allowed to go? Pause this audio here.

Then James talks about the people who break this law by showing favoritism, or honoring some people more than other people. James talks about people who show favoritism in the same way he talks about a criminal in a courtroom. James describes the people who show favoritism as if they are in court, where the authorities accuse those people of doing something wrong. James describes the law as if it were the judge in the courtroom. This judge—the law—looks at the actions of those people who show favoritism and decides they are guilty of breaking the law.

James then says that if you only disobey one of God's laws, it is the same as disobeying all of God's laws. All of God's laws are important, and God expects his people to obey all of his laws. If someone disobeys even one of God's laws, they are still guilty! Then James gives an example: If someone commits murder but never commits adultery, that person is still a lawbreaker because God told us not to murder and not to commit adultery. You will remember that someone who commits murder makes a plan to kill someone and then kills that person. And you will remember that a person who commits adultery has a sexual relationship with somebody who is not that person's husband or wife.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about somebody who keeps most, but not all, of the community's rules. Then tell a story about a person who breaks many of the community's rules. Do you punish these people differently because one has broken only one law, and the other has broken many laws? How does your community treat someone who breaks one rule differently from someone who breaks many rules? Why? Pause this audio here.

In an earlier part of his letter, James reminded the believers that God wants them to obey the law that gives people freedom, or sets people free from sin. This is God's law that he gave his people, and it includes the teachings of Jesus. This perfect, or complete, law releases us to obey God's laws completely. This is good news, and this makes believers want to completely obey God's laws! Now James reminds the believers about this law. When the believers remember to obey this law, they will speak and act in the way Jesus taught people to live. When the believers do, they will show mercy, or kindness, to people around them. The law that sets people free helps people want to do good things because they love God, not because they are afraid of being punished. When people live like this, they forgive each other, and they are kind or have mercy for one another. This law that gives freedom is the law that God will use to decide whether people are innocent or guilty. So believers should follow this law, and they should show mercy to others.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your community, what rules do people follow because they are frightened of what will happen to them if they do not follow the rules? How do people feel about these rules? How would your community be different if people did good things because they wanted to, not because they had to? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your community, what rules cause people to feel free and happy when they follow those rules? How do those rules help people treat other people with kindness? Pause this audio here.

James finishes this part of his letter with a warning and an encouragement. On the day at the end of this world when God decides whether people are innocent or guilty, God will not show mercy toward the people who have not shown mercy to other people. James does not say this, but James strongly suggests that God *will* show mercy to the people who have shown mercy to other people. If a person shows mercy to other people, it means the person chooses to say and do kind things to people who need kind words or actions but who may not deserve them. It is like the person who says and does kind things to people has won against an enemy! That person is not afraid that God will judge him to be wrong.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of James 2:8–13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the parts, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four parts.

In the first part: James tells the believers they are doing the right thing if they are keeping the law "to love your neighbour as yourself."

In the second part: James tells the believers that if they are showing favouritism, or honoring some people more than others, they are breaking God's law.

In the third part: James tells the believers to obey the law that gives freedom.

In the fourth part: James gives the believers a warning.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- Believers who honour some believers more than others
- Believers who break one law, but not all of them
- Believers who show mercy
- Believers who do not show mercy
- And God

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first part, James tells the believers they are doing the right thing if they keep the royal law. A royal law is a law that a king gives. God rules as king over all people, and God gave this law: "to love your neighbour as yourself."

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, what do you call a law that a king or the highest ruler gives? How important is that kind of law? Then discuss as a group how you will translate "royal law" here. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and tell a story about a person who is your neighbor. Pay attention to how you talk about that person and what you call them. Then discuss how you want to translate the way that God has said to love your neighbor in the same way you love yourself. You may listen to your translation of Luke 10:27 to hear how you translated it there. Pause this audio here.

So the believers should show love to everybody they meet. To love somebody means we choose to do kind things for people, and respect people, and look after their physical needs. We do these things for ourselves, and we should love each other in the same way! James tells the believers that if they are "keeping" or obeying this law, they are doing the right thing.

In the second part, James talks about the believers who do not follow this law. These people honor some people more than others, or show favoritism. James compares the person who shows favoritism to someone on trial in a courtroom. James describes the law as if it were a judge in the courtroom. The judge—or the law—looks at the actions of those who show favoritism and decides they are guilty of breaking the law.

Stop here and tell a story about a person who had to go to a judge, and the judge decided that the person was guilty, or had broken a law. What words or phrases do you have for the way that a judge decides that someone is guilty of breaking a law? Discuss how you want to translate the way that the law is like a judge that decides people are guilty. Pause this audio here.

James then says that if you only disobey one of God's laws, it is the same as disobeying all of God's laws. James uses special language to describe the way a person disobeys God's laws. James says that the person stumbles or almost falls down. If that person stumbles, or disobeys, just one law, they are still guilty, which means that they are still a person who breaks God's law! Then James gives an example: if someone commits murder but never commits adultery, he is still a lawbreaker.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will describe the special language that someone stumbles over, or disobeys, one law. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will describe that when a person disobeys one law, it is the same as if they disobey the entire law. That person is still a guilty person, even if they break just one law! Pause this audio here.

In the third part, James tells the believers that they must speak and act like people who know that God will use the law that gives freedom to decide whether people are innocent or guilty. When James talks about the law that sets people free, James means that when people follow what Jesus taught them, they have a new

way of living. This is even better than the old rules people used to follow. James calls it the “law of freedom, or liberty” because it frees people from feeling like they cannot stop doing bad things. The law that sets people free helps people want to do good things because they love God, not because they are afraid that God will punish them. This new law teaches people to love God and be kind to others. When people live like this, they forgive each other, and they are kind to each other. In other words, these people show mercy to each other.

Stop here and remember your discussion from step two about rules that make people feel free and happy. Discuss how you want to translate “the law that gives people freedom.” James still calls this law by the same name—a “law”—but this “law” brings freedom, not judgment. Pause this audio here.

In the fourth part, James gives the believers a warning. James warns the believers that on the day when God decides whether people are innocent or guilty, God will not show mercy toward the people who have not shown mercy to other people. James does not say, but implies, that God *will* show mercy to the people who have shown mercy to other people. If a person shows mercy to other people, it means the person chooses to say and do kind things to people who need kind words or actions but who may not deserve them. James then says that mercy is victorious, or wins, over judgment. James talks about mercy like it were a person who defeats another person. James means that the person who shows mercy to people is not afraid that God will condemn him.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it. You may want to have different objects or people to represent James, the believers, and God. You may want to have some of the believers honouring some believers more than others. You can choose a group of items, such as sticks, to represent the commands in the law. Someone can carry these items to represent the way that someone obeys the law. But then have that person pretend to trip and drop one of those items to represent the way a person stumbles and disobeys one of the laws. You may want to show some believers showing mercy, or kindness, to other believers, and other believers not showing mercy to other believers. You may want to show God judging the believers in the same way that they have treated the other believers.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of James 2:8–13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- Believers who honour some believers more than others
- Believers who break one law, but not all of them
- Believers who show mercy
- Believers who do not show mercy
- And God

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first part, James tells the believers they are doing the right thing if they are keeping the royal law “to love your neighbour as yourself.” James tells the believers that if they are “keeping” or obeying this law, they are doing the right thing.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers who are keeping the law, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel very proud of myself. I am doing good things for people who do not deserve them; or
- I am glad that I can show love to other people in the same way that Jesus has shown his love for us.

Continue the drama.

In the second part, James talks about the believers who honor some people more than others, or show favoritism. When these people show favoritism, these people sin. The law shows that these people have disobeyed the law.

James then says that if you only disobey one of God’s laws, it is the same as disobeying all of God’s laws. Then James gives an example: if someone commits murder but never commits adultery, he is still a lawbreaker because God told us not to murder and not to commit adultery.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers who have only broken one rule, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am angry that people say that I am a lawbreaker. I am a good person. I have only done a few things wrong. I am not like those people who have broken lots of rules; or
- I am ashamed. I did not understand that if I broke one law, then I am as guilty as the person who has broken lots of laws.

Continue the drama.

In the third part, James tells the believers that they must speak and act like people who know that one day God will decide if the believers are innocent or guilty. God will decide using the law that sets the believers free from sin.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing James, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am so glad that I can remind the believers about the good news that God judges believers by the law of freedom, and not by the old law; or
- I am sad that I cannot be with the believers when they hear this letter I am writing to them. I would like to remind them of this good news in person.

Continue the drama.

In the fourth part, James warns the believers that on that day when God decides whether people are innocent or guilty, God will not show mercy toward the people who have not shown mercy to other people. The person who says and does kind things to people is not afraid that God will condemn him, because mercy is stronger than judgement.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers who have shown mercy to other people, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- Sometimes it is hard to show mercy to people, but I remember that God has shown mercy to me, so I want to show mercy to other people; or
- It gives me joy to know that because I show mercy to people, God will continue to show mercy to me.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of James 2:8–13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

James tells the believers to keep the royal **law** that is in Scripture. It is called the royal law because royal refers to things that come from kings. This law comes from God, who is the most important king of everything. Use the same word or phrase for law as you have used in previous passages. Refer to law in the Master Glossary for more information.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate the special phrase for **royal law**. Pause this audio here.

James also says the law comes from Scripture. Here, “Scripture” means God’s words that people have written down in the Old Testament.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Scripture**. Look up scriptures in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James is talking to the believers about the law that says to “love your neighbor as yourself.” People usually thought of a neighbor as someone who lived in the same community as they did.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **neighbor**. Look up neighbor in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James says that people **sin** when they show favoritism. When people sin, they disobey God and rebel against God. Use the same word or phrase for sin as you have used previously, and refer to sin in the Master Glossary for more information.

If someone stumbles and disobeys a law, that person is guilty of breaking all of the law. Someone who is guilty has sinned or disobeyed God. That person deserves for God to punish them.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **guilty**. For more information about guilt, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

James talks to the believers about the **law that gives freedom**. James is talking about the new way of living that Jesus taught. This is different from the old rules people used to follow. James calls it the law that gives freedom, or the law of liberty, because it frees people from feeling like they cannot stop doing bad things. Sin no longer has control of these people. Use the same word or phrase for “law that gives freedom” that you used in previous passages.

James uses a person who murders but does not commit adultery as an example. To murder someone means to make a plan to kill someone and then do so, often secretly, so that no one will stop you. In this case, adultery refers to when people have a sexual relationship with someone to whom they are not married.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **murder** and **adultery**. Look up adultery in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James finishes this passage by talking about what will happen to people who do not show mercy to other people. If a person shows mercy to other people, it means the person chooses to say and do kind things to people who need kind words or actions but who may not deserve them.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **mercy**. Look up mercy in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers that God will judge and not show mercy to people who do not show mercy to other people. When a person judges someone else, it means that they decide whether that person is guilty or innocent of doing a wrong thing.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **judge** and **judgment**. Look up judge in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

James 2:14–26

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear James 2:14–26 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of James 2:14–26 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of James 2:14–26 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, James told the believers that if they honour some people more than others, they are breaking God's law. Now James makes it clear to the believers that if a person has real faith in Jesus, that person will not only believe in Jesus but also do good actions.

James starts this part of his letter by emphasizing that the believers should already know and understand that if a person says they believe in Jesus, but they do not also do good actions, that kind of faith is useless. The believers should also know that God will not save a person who has faith like that. James gives an example of a believer who says kind words, but does not help a person who needs food or clothes. This believer does not do any good for anyone!

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a person in your community who is a good person. What makes them a good person? Is it because of what they say, or because of what they do, or both? Pause this audio here.

James describes a believer who does not have food to eat that day, nor the clothes they need to keep warm. Another believer talks to the poor believer and says, "Go in peace." This was something that people often said as a goodbye. The believer also says, "Keep warm and well fed." These words are like a wish, or a prayer, that the poor person will be warm and eat a lot of food. But the believer does not give the poor believer any clothes or food! James makes it clear that if the believers have faith but do not do good works, then the faith is as useless as a dead thing and worthless.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about somebody in your community who is hungry or poor. Who is responsible for looking after this person? What would you say to this hungry or poor person? What could you do for this person? Pause this audio here.

James knows that when people hear what James says, someone will disagree with James. Someone may say that there are two ways that God saves people. This person says that God saves some people because they trust in Jesus and some people because they do good things.

James challenges anyone who thinks like this to prove that they have true faith when they do not do good actions to prove it. However, people will know that James' faith is real because James also does good actions. James knows that people who disagree with James also say they believe in "one God." The Jewish believers would know and understand the statement "one God" because it was an important statement in Jewish worship. James means that these people accept that there is really one true God. But these people do not trust God and follow God. James wants the believers to understand that there is a difference between when people believe that God is real and when people trust in and follow God.

James says that demons also believe that God is real, but the demons do not trust and follow God. Demons are evil spiritual beings who follow the devil. The demons are so afraid of God that they shake all over. God certainly does not save the demons. So the believers cannot just believe that God is real, like the demons do. The believers must believe and trust in Jesus in a different way, in a deeper way that changes people's lives and leads to good deeds!

James calls anyone who thinks like this a foolish person or an "empty" person. The person is "empty" because that person does not have wise thoughts. James then talks about Abraham and Rahab. These are two people from the Old Testament stories who God considered righteous because they trusted God and acted in a right way.

First, James talks about Abraham. God told Abraham to sacrifice Abraham's son, Isaac, on an altar. An altar is a type of platform on which people offer "sacrifices," or gifts to God. Abraham obeyed God and took Isaac to an altar, but God stopped Abraham before Abraham had to kill Isaac. God provided an animal for Abraham to sacrifice instead.

Stop here and look at a picture of an altar as a group. Pause this audio here.

Abraham showed that Abraham had faith in God by what Abraham did. Because of how Abraham obeyed God, God decided that Abraham was righteous. Someone who is righteous is in a right relationship with God,

and God accepts that person. James uses Abraham's story to show that when a person truly trusts in God, that person will act in a good way. So a person's faith is not complete until they act in a good way because of what they believe.

James shows that in another part of Scripture, it says that Abraham trusted God and God considered Abraham righteous. The story of how Abraham was willing to sacrifice Isaac shows how that other part of Scripture is certainly true. James also says that Abraham is God's friend, which shows that Abraham had a good relationship with God. James explains that God declares a person is righteous when that person has the kind of faith that causes them to do good actions as well as to believe and trust God.

James then talks about Rahab, another example of a person in the Old Testament whom God said was righteous. Rahab was a non-Jewish woman who lived in Jericho. Rahab was also a prostitute. A prostitute is a woman who has sex with men in exchange for money. Rahab welcomed some Israelite men who came to spy on the city of Jericho. Rahab hid the men and then sent them out of the city by a safe path. God decided Rahab was righteous because of how Rahab acted.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when a person who was not part of your community did good things for people in your community. The leader of your community welcomed this person into your community because of the person's good actions. How did the community feel about this person? Pause this audio here.

James tells the believers they need to understand that when someone says they trust God but does not do good actions, that faith is dead, just like a body that does not breathe is dead. Some translations say a body without a spirit, or the inner part of a person, is dead. If someone says they believe in God, but they do not do good things, their belief is as useless as a body that is not alive.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about the faith or spiritual beliefs of your community or culture. How do these beliefs make a difference in the daily life of the people in your community?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of James 2:14–26 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the parts, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four parts.

In the first part: James is talking to the believers. James asks the believers three questions that he does not expect the believers to answer. James wants the believers to understand that if the believers have faith but do not do good works, then the faith is as useless as a dead thing and worthless.

In the second part: James has an imaginary conversation with another person who does not agree with what James is saying. The person who does not agree with James is not real but represents everybody who does not agree with what James is saying. In the imaginary conversation, James talks about Abraham as an example of a righteous person.

In the third part: James speaks to the believers again and explains that a person is righteous, or has a good or right relationship with God, when they do good actions as well as believe and trust God. James then talks about another example of a righteous person. James talks about Rahab.

In the fourth part: James makes a statement about what faith without good actions is like.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- The believers
- A poor brother or sister

- The person that James is talking to in the imaginary conversation
- Abraham
- Isaac
- Rahab
- The Israelite messengers
- And God

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first part, James is talking to believers. James calls the believers “brothers and sisters,” although they are not blood relatives. You will remember that James often uses the phrase “brothers” or “brothers and sisters” to show that he is going to start talking about something different.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell the group about something that you want the group to know. Then give the group some new and different information. Pay attention to the words, phrases, and gestures you use so that the group knows you are telling them something different. Pause this audio here.

James starts by asking three questions to emphasize something that the believers should already know and understand. James does not expect the believers to answer the questions. Firstly, James asks if people can claim to trust in Jesus but not do anything because of that trust. The believers should already know that if a person says they have faith, but they do not also do good actions, that kind of faith is useless. Secondly, James asks if that kind of faith or trust saves a person. The believers should already know that God will not save a person from the punishment for their sins if they say they have faith in God but do not do good actions. Thirdly, James asks what good a believer does if they say kind things to a believer who does not have clothes or food, but they do not help that believer. The believers should already know that if a person says kind words to a person who has practical needs, but does not help that person, the kind words do not help the person who speaks them or the person in need.

When James asks the third question, he describes an example of a person who has faith but who does not do good actions. This could be just an example, but it could also be a real situation that had actually happened. In James' example, one of the believers speaks to the poor person. The believer says “Go in peace,” which is a way to say goodbye, and wishes that the poor believer would be warm and well-fed. But the believer does not do anything for the poor person. James uses the three questions and the example of the poor person to make it clear to the believers that if the believers have faith but do not do good works, then the faith is as useless as a dead thing and worthless.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about somebody who was leaving your house to go on a journey. Are there special gestures, words, or phrases that you use when the person leaves? Will this change how you translate what the believer says to the poor person in the example that James gives? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are some dead things that are useless in your culture? How would you compare something to those dead items to show that both are useless to you? Discuss how you want to translate the way that James says this kind of faith is useless. Pause this audio here.

In the second part, James describes an imaginary conversation between James and another person who does not agree with what James is saying. The conversation did not really happen. The person who does not agree with James is not real but represents everybody who does not agree with what James is saying. James uses the conversation to help explain to the believers that God only saves people who show that their faith is real by acting rightly and well.

In the conversation, the imaginary person says that one person can have faith without doing good actions, and another person can do good actions without having faith. James says that people will know that James' faith is real because James also does good things.

In the imaginary conversation, James says that the other person believes in “one God.” The Jewish believers would know and understand the statement “one God” because it was an important statement in Jewish worship. Other people believed in many gods, so this statement showed that the Jews were different from other people. While this statement is true, James shows that this is the most basic thing a person can believe about God. What James means is that there is a difference between just believing that God is real and having faith and trusting and following in God.

Stop here and tell a story about someone who believes there is one God but is not a believer. Or tell a story about someone who believes that a human leader is real, but does not follow or obey that leader. How is the way that person believes different than the way you believe in God? Discuss how you want to translate the way that James talks about someone who believes there is one God, but does not do more than just believe God is real. Pause this audio here.

In the imaginary conversation, James tells the other person that knowing God is real is a good thing, but it is not enough. James says that demons also believe that God is real, but the demons do not trust and follow God. The demons are so afraid of God that they shake all over. Demons are evil spiritual beings who follow the devil. What James means is that true faith must be more than just knowing about God; true faith must change a person’s life and make them want to do good actions.

In the imaginary conversation, James continues to talk to the other person. James rebukes the other person and calls him a foolish person. In the original language, James says that the person is “empty” because he does not have wise thoughts.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when you were talking to a person who was foolish or unwise. What gestures, words, or phrases do you use when you are telling that person that they are foolish or unwise? What words will you use to translate “foolish” in this passage? Pause this audio here.

Then James asks another question that he does not expect anyone to answer. James asks if it is true that God considered Abraham righteous because of what Abraham did. James uses the question to start talking about Abraham. Abraham was a person in Old Testament stories. In one Old Testament story, God asked Abraham to build an altar. Abraham built an altar from stone. Then God told Abraham to take Abraham’s son, Isaac, to the altar and sacrifice him on the altar. Isaac was not a small child. Isaac was old enough to carry the wood that Abraham needed to make the sacrifice. Abraham obeyed God, but God stopped Abraham before Abraham had to kill Isaac.

James calls Abraham “our father.” Abraham was not the literal father of James. Abraham was an ancestor of the Jewish people. James and all the Jewish believers were descendants of Abraham.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about the ancestor who was the beginning of your language group or tribe. What words do you use to describe this person? How will you talk about Abraham as the “father” of James and all the Jewish believers? Pause this audio here.

In the New Testament stories, people often talk about Abraham as a good example of a person who has faith. James says that God considered Abraham righteous. This means that God decided that Abraham was in a right relationship with God, and that God accepted him, because Abraham’s actions showed that Abraham had faith in God.

James then repeats some words from the first book of the Bible. The words come from the story about when Abraham trusted God’s promise that his descendants would be as many as the stars in the night sky.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: If you have already translated the story in Genesis 15:6, when God promised Abraham that Abraham’s descendants would be as many as the stars in the night sky, listen to the story again. Use the same words here that you used in that story for “Abraham believed God and God considered Abraham righteous.” Pause this audio here.

James says that God has fulfilled those words from the Old Testament. Here, “fulfilled” means that the words were true. When Abraham was willing to sacrifice Isaac, this showed that Abraham really did believe and trust God. It showed that the earlier words about Abraham being righteous were correct. Abraham’s willingness to obey God showed that his faith in God was real.

James also says that Abraham is God’s friend. There are two other places in the Old Testament where God calls Abraham “my friend.” A friend is a companion who has the same purpose with you. This shows that Abraham is righteous, or in a good relationship with God.

In the third part, James stops the imaginary conversation and talks to the believers again. James explains that a person is righteous, or has a good or right relationship with God, when they do good actions as well as believe and trust God.

James asks another question that he does not expect anyone to answer. James does this to start talking about another example of a person in the Old Testament whom God said was righteous, or in a good or right relationship with God. James asks if God considered Rahab righteous because of how Rahab acted. Rahab was a non-Jewish woman who lived in Jericho. Rahab was also a prostitute. A prostitute is a woman who has sexual relations with men in exchange for money. Rahab welcomed some Israelite messengers who came secretly to find out about the city of Jericho. Rahab gave them shelter and then sent them out of the city by a safe way. God decided Rahab was righteous because of her good actions.

In the fourth part, James finishes by repeating what he said earlier in this passage. James tells the believers that they need to understand that faith without good actions is dead. But this time, James describes faith as if it were a person’s body. If a body does not have breath, it is dead. If a person’s faith does not include good actions, it is also dead.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it. You may want to use objects or people to show James, the believers, and God. You may also want to use objects or people to show the people that James was telling stories about: a poor brother or sister, the person that James is talking to in the imaginary conversation, Abraham, Isaac, Rahab, and the Israelite messengers.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of James 2:14–26 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- James
- The believers
- A poor brother or sister
- The person that James is talking to in the imaginary conversation
- Abraham
- Isaac
- Rahab
- The Israelite messengers
- And God

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first part, James calls the believers “brothers and sisters.” James says that if a person says they have faith, but they do not also do good actions, that kind of faith is useless. That type of faith will certainly not save the believers from God’s punishment for sin.

James then describes a situation where one of the believers speaks to a poor believer. The believer says goodbye to the poor believer and wishes the poor believer would be warm and well-fed. However, the believer does not do anything for the poor person. This is no help at all! James makes it clear that if the believers have faith but do not do good works, then the faith is as useless as a dead thing and worthless.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the poor person, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- The believers are saying good things to me, but I am still hungry and cold. The words that they speak do not mean anything to me; or
- I thought the believers would help me, but they just want me to go away; or
- I do not believe that God loves me. I thought believers were meant to do what God wants them to do. It looks like God does not want them to help me.

Continue the drama.

In the second part, James describes an imaginary conversation between James and another person who does not agree with what James is saying. When you are acting this out, remember that the conversation did not really happen.

James says that someone may say that one person can have faith without doing good actions, and another person can do good actions without having faith. James asks if that person can prove that they trust in Jesus Christ when that person does not do good deeds. James can show that James really believes in Jesus by the good actions that James does.

James says that the other person believes in “one God.” But James says that knowing God is real is a good thing, but it is not enough. Demons also believe that God is real, but the demons do not trust and follow God. The demons are so afraid of God that they shake all over. James rebukes the other person and calls him a foolish person. James asks if the foolish person needs proof that when someone has faith but does not do good deeds, such faith is no good?

James tells that person to think about their ancestor Abraham. God said that Abraham was a righteous person because of the way Abraham was willing to sacrifice Abraham’s son, Isaac, on the altar. It is clear that Abraham not only trusted in God but also did what God wanted Abraham to do. So the way Abraham acted showed that Abraham’s faith was real.

The way Abraham acted showed that what someone wrote in the Scripture about Abraham was really true. The Scripture says that Abraham trusted God, and that is why God called Abraham righteous and God’s friend.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I knew that Abraham was a righteous man, but I have never understood that it was because of what Abraham did, not just because of what he believed; or

- It is helpful when James explains what he is talking about by reminding us of stories that we know well.

Continue the drama.

In the third part, James explains that a person is righteous, or has a good or right relationship with God, when that person does good actions that show they trust God.

James then talks about Rahab, whom God also said was righteous because of how she acted. Rahab was a prostitute. Rahab welcomed some Israelite men who came secretly to find out about the city of Jericho. Rahab gave these men shelter and then sent them out of the city by a safe way.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- This story of Rahab reminds me that anybody can have a good relationship with God if that person trusts God and does good actions, even if they are not a Jew like me; or
- I do not like this story. I still do not understand how God can have a good relationship with somebody like Rahab, who does not live in a good way.

Continue the drama.

In the fourth part, James tells the believers that they need to understand that faith without deeds is dead, just like a body that does not have breath is dead.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the believers, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- James has helped me to understand that when I say I believe in God, that is not enough. I need to show by good actions that I follow God and trust him; or
- James is telling me that my faith is like a dead body because I do not do good actions. I feel very uncomfortable.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of James 2:14–26 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

James addresses the believers as his **brothers and sisters**. Use the same word or phrase that you used for “dear brothers and sisters” in the previous passage.

James is telling the believers that they need to do good actions and they need to have **faith**. If a person has faith in somebody, it means they trust and commit to follow that person. For more information on faith, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase that you used for faith in the previous passage.

One of the believers may say to another, “Go in peace.” People often used this phrase to bless someone, to say goodbye, and to reassure someone.

Stop here and discuss as a group what phrase you will use for “**go in peace**.” Look up “go in peace” in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same phrase that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

In the imaginary conversation, James says that the other person believes in one God and that the demons also believe in the one God. In the original language, James uses the same word here for “believe” as he used for “faith” earlier in the passage. Here, the same word has a different meaning. Here, James means that if a person believes something, it just means that that person knows something is true or real. James wants

the believers to understand that there is a difference between believing that God is real and having faith and trusting and following in God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **believe** when it just means to believe that something is real. Pause this audio here.

James says that the other person believes in one God and that the demons also believe in the one God. The Jewish believers would know and understand the words “one God” because they were important words in Jewish worship.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for believing in “**one God**.” The words come from the Old Testament story in Deuteronomy 6:4, where Moses is speaking to the Jewish people for the last time. If you have already translated that story, use the same word or phrase here. Pause this audio here.

James says that even the demons believe in one God and are afraid of God. Demons are evil spiritual beings who follow the devil.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **demons**. Look up demon in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word here. Pause this audio here.

James says that foolish people want him to prove that they must also do good things. A foolish person acts in an unwise way. James gives the example of Abraham, who offered his son on the altar. Abraham was the ancestor of the Jewish people. An altar is a place where people make offerings or sacrifices to God. An altar is like a table or a platform that people make of earth or large stones.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **foolish** person and for **altar**, and what name you will use for **Abraham**. Look up fool, altar, and Abraham in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words here. Pause this audio here.

James reminds the believers that the **Scripture** says that Abraham was a righteous man. Scripture, or the Scriptures, is what we now call the Old Testament. Look up Scripture in the Master Glossary for more information, and use the same word or phrase you used in previous passages in James.

James gives the example of Abraham and reminds the believers that God said that Abraham was a **righteous** man. This means that Abraham was in a good relationship with God. Look up righteousness in the Master Glossary for more information and use the same word or phrase for righteous as you have used in previous passages.

At the end of this passage, James says that faith without good actions is dead, in the same way that a body without the spirit is dead. Here, spirit means the air that a person breathes into his or her body, which gives them life. When that person stops breathing, the person dies. James is describing faith as if it were a person's body. If faith does not have works, in the same way as a body does not have breath, it is also dead.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **spirit**, and refer to spirit in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word here.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.